

Nàngásánshú

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1 Phonology

Elvish has no rounded vowels or labial consonants as Elves have no lips. They also have a rather stiff tongue, which leads to a lack of apical sounds as well as the palatal and velar places of articulation collapsing together.

All Elvish consonants are egressive, and all vowels are ingressive. This means that the articulation of an Elvish word requires the speaker to constantly flip-flop between breathing in and breathing out.

Due to their extensive and perpetual involvement in and with the Coal mining process, the mouth of an Elf is exceedingly dry and covered in Coal dust, rendering Elvish articulation particularly chalky, grating, and stunted.

1.1 Consonants

	Alveolar	Palato-Velar	Uvulo-Glottal
Nasal			$\text{n}^?$ ⟨n⟩
Stop	$\text{d} \text{ t}$ ⟨d t⟩	$\text{c} \text{ k}$ ⟨c g⟩	ʔ ⟨ʔ⟩
Fricative	$\text{s} \text{ s}^{\text{h}}$ ⟨s sh⟩	$\text{ç} \text{ x}$ ⟨ch x⟩	
Affricate	$\text{ts} \text{ ts}^{\text{h}}$ ⟨ts tsh⟩	$\text{tch} \text{ tx}$ ⟨tch tx⟩	
Trill		r ⟨r⟩	

- ◇ r / r^{h} is a coarticulated palatal-velar trill (yes, Elves can do that)

1.2 Vowels

	Front	Back	Click
Close	$\text{i} \text{ i}^{\text{h}}$ ⟨i í⟩	$\text{u} \text{ u}^{\text{h}}$ ⟨u ú⟩	
Open	$\text{a} \text{ a}^{\text{h}}$ ⟨a á⟩		
Palato-velar			k^{h} ⟨o⟩

- ◇ Tense/lax distinction. Lax vowels are marked with an acute.
- ◇ Ingressive sounds are considered vowels, and thus, the palatal-velar click is a vowel.
- ◇ Any vowel can be followed by f^{h} ⟨ f^{h} ⟩, which signifies the ‘velar quality’, e.g. $\text{ú} / \text{ú}^{\text{h}} \text{f}^{\text{h}} \downarrow$.

1.3 Phonotactics

Classes

C = d, t, c, g, s, sh, ch, x, r, n

A = ts, tsh, tch, tx

V = i, í, u, ú, a, á, o

Q = .

Phonotactics

$[\text{C}|\text{A}]\text{V}(\text{Q})((\text{n}|\text{r})([\text{C}|\text{' }]\text{V}(\text{Q})))|\text{V}(\text{Q})[(\text{n}|\text{r})\text{C}]\text{V}(\text{Q})$

Example word

$\text{tsh} \text{ q}^{\text{h}} / \text{ts}^{\text{h}} \text{ k}^{\text{h}} \text{ f}^{\text{h}} \text{ r}^{\text{h}} \text{ k}^{\text{h}} \text{ f}^{\text{h}} /$ ‘ribbon’

2 Grammar

2.1 Work Order

Animacy is vital to determining word order in Elvish. The highest animacy, and thus primacy in a clause, goes to that which is working the hardest. This is ‘Work Order.’ From highest work order to lowest, the classes are as follows:

1. The Chimney Man (w₁)
In any circumstance in which The Chimney Man is referenced, He will always have the highest Work Order, for He is always working the Hardest. Except for the day after Christmas.
Any *constituents* containing a w₁ word are placed at the very start of the sentence even before the verb and its markers. This excludes any nested phrases with lesser work order, which must be extraposed using SAPs.
2. Coal (w₂)
Coal is considered the most important aspect of Elvish society and thus placed just below The Chimney Man. It is also considered capable of performing more work than any Elf as it generates a lot of energy when burnt (unlike Elves). Amongst Elves, only the Grand Carbonator is assigned a work order of 2 (see § 5.2).
3. Master Carbonator (w₃)
The highest social status that a normal Elf can obtain; the council of Master Carbonators rules over Elvish society and reports directly to the Grand Carbonator (see § 5.2).
4. Collier (w₄)
Highly experienced Elves that have been working in the Coal industry for at least 100 years; these are typically regional overseers. Only Elves at the class of Collier or above enjoy the privilege of having their names capitalised in writing, and only they are entitled to wear cloaks (see § 5.3).
5. Head Miner (w₅)
Elf in charge of a Coal mine.
6. Canary (w₆)
Used for both the lowest class of Elves (i.e. the common Coal miner) as well as the bird.
7. Human Coal Miners (w₇)
Used for human Coal miners.
8. Human Adults (w₈)
Used for any other human adult.
9. Animals (w₉)
Used for any animal.
10. Human Children (w₁₀)
Used for human children (that are not Coal miners). While important to Elvish society as the beneficiaries of their toils, they are deemed the laziest of beings.
11. Everything Else (w₁₁)
Genreally, any inanimate object other than Coal, abstract concepts, etc.

Some words may have work orders that aren’t obvious from their semantics, e.g. the word *shúmq* /ʃhúmq/ ‘retirement’ has work order 4 as it is considered a culturally important part of Elvish society.

2.2 Work Order Marking

There are two ways in which work order may be expressed. First, most lexical words (except verbs) have an inherent work order, e.g. *díǵá* /dɪ¹ǵe¹/ ‘cane’ always has work order 11. In addition to this, there is also a set of work order markers that may be placed before a word to raise or lower its default work order. These affixes are as follows:

±	Raising Affix	Lowering Affix
1	<i>natá</i> /nʰaʔtɛ↓/	<i>tchichá</i> /čkčxi↓čxɛʔ↓/
2	<i>cíčhq</i> /čkrʔ↓čxaʔ↓/	<i>tsqno</i> /tʂaʔ↓nʔʔkʰ↓/
3	<i>úncho</i> /ũʔ↓nʔʔkʰ↓/	<i>tchqn'ú</i> /čkčxaʔ↓nʔʔũʔ↓/
4	<i>tchixi</i> /čkčxi↓čxʰi↓/	<i>cáru</i> /čkɛ↓rɹu↓/
5	<i>txúnsha</i> /čkčxʰũʔ↓nʔʂʰa↓/	<i>shindy</i> /ʂʰiʔ↓nʔɖuʔ↓/
6	<i>xúnna</i> /čxʰũ↓nʔʰaʔ↓/	<i>xúnra</i> /čxʰũ↓nʔʔɹɛ↓/
7	<i>txadá</i> /čkčxʰa↓ɖɛʔ↓/	<i>gincú</i> /jgiʔ↓nʔčkũʔ↓/
8	<i>xíntí</i> /čxʰɪʔ↓nʔtɪ↓/	<i>shatú</i> /ʂʰa↓tũ↓/
9	<i>shítɔ</i> /ʂʰɪʔ↓tɪkʰʔ↓/	<i>xɔnchu</i> /čxʰkʰʔ↓nʔčxuʔ↓/
10	<i>shindí</i> /ʂʰi↓nʔɖɪ↓/	<i>oxa</i> /kʰčxʰa↓/

Table 1: Work Order Markers

For example, forming *xúnnq dígá* has the effect of raising the work order of *dígá* to w5 (since $11 - 6 = 5$); thus, this phrase is suitable for referring to a cane that performs as much work as a Head Miner (whatever that means). There are a few things that one needs to keep in mind here:

- ◇ Attempting to raise/lower the work order of a noun below the minimum (w₁₁) above the maximum (w₁) work order is ungrammatical.
- ◇ The ‘lowest’ work order is 11 and the ‘highest’ is 1, thus ‘raising’ counterintuitively occurs from a larger number to a smaller number, and ‘lowering’ from a smaller number to a larger number, e.g. work order 5 can be ‘raised’ to 4 or ‘lowered’ to 6.
- ◇ Lowering the work order of a noun with default work order w₁ is generally done to refer to people who have an inflated self of ego, e.g. a Master Carbonator who starts trying to order around the rest of the council as though it were the Chimney Man Himself may be referred to as an *tsaŋ'o sántá /t͡sa^ŋ↓N[?]ʔ^k† sɔ^ŋ↓N[?]tɕ^ŋ↓/* ‘Master Carbonator who acts as though it were The Chimney Man’ (lit. ‘Chimney Man’ lowered to work order w₃).
- ◇ Note that in this sense, lowering generally has the effect of expressing disdain, denigrating something, or making something seem less important or fake (this is known as ‘derogatory lowering’), whereas raising is typically a form of praise.
- ◇ The inverse is generally acceptable, e.g. *shindí dígá /ʃ^hi↓N[?]ɖ^h↓ d^hr^ŋ↓jge↓/* ‘A cane made personally by The Chimney Man’.
- ◇ As we just saw, work order raising/lowering can be used to communicate that an otherwise low-status being or object (or high-status being or object) is in some manner closely associated with something or someone of higher status (or lower status), e.g. *xúnnq dígá* can also refer to a cane that belongs to a Head Miner.

2.2.1 Work Order and Elision

Generic nouns such as *xáŋgá* / $\widehat{\text{X}}^{\text{h}}\text{v}^{\text{f}}\downarrow\text{N}^{\text{f}}\}\widehat{\text{g}}\text{v}\downarrow$ / ‘thing’ as well as numbers can be combined with a work order marker to refer to something in the context that has that work order. For example, an

ínú /ɪ^ŋ↓N[?]ú↓/ ‘minecart’, which has work order w6, may be referred to later on as *txúnsha xángá* /čkčx^hú^ŋ↓N[?]s^ha↓ čx^hú^ŋ↓N[?]ŋe↓/ ‘the thing with work order w6’. This is an alternative to SAPs (see § 2.3.2) and is especially common with numbers and things that have a relatively high work order.

2.3 Adjectives

In sequences of adjectives (which Elves are particularly prone to), the following categories of hierarchy of importance determines the order at which they are uttered:

1. Christmas
2. Coal
3. Elves
4. Work
5. Humans
6. Rest

Adjectives precede the noun they qualify.

2.3.1 Adverbs

Adverbs follow the verb.

2.3.2 Standalone Adjective Phrases (SAPs)

A very common idiom in Elvish is to refer to a noun (phrase) in the domain of discourse by an adjective that describes it, optionally preceded by a work order marker that agrees with the work order of the noun (phrase). Such phrases are known as *standalone adjective phrases* (SAPs) this largely replaces pronouns in Elvish.

SAPs consist of an adjective preceded by a so-called *invoice particle* (see § 2.3.2.1); syntactically, SAPs are treated as though they were nouns; in particular, they may be preceded by the usual noun particles and even other adjectives.

In writing, it is common for the first mention of a noun phrase to be accompanied by one or more adjectives that may later on be used to refer to it.¹ For example, a fat Elf with the name *txqncu* /čkčx^hú^ŋ↓N[?]čku^ŋ↓/ might be introduced as *txúdí txqncu* ‘Fat Txqncu’ and then later on referred to as *sí txúdí* /sɪ^ŋ↓ čkčx^hú^ŋ↓dɪ↓/ ‘the fat one’, where *sí* is one of the possible invoice particles.

SAPs are capitalised if they refer to a noun that is capitalised.

2.3.2.1 Invoice

The *invoice* is a construction used primarily as part of a SAP. An invoice operates in a similar way to adjective-noun agreement, except that it is really clause-noun agreement. That is, each noun is assigned a ‘tense’ based on its initial phoneme (see Table 2), and the appropriate invoice particle depends on the noun’s inherent tense as well as the syntactic tense of the clause. Tenses are assigned an integer value *v* between 1 and 5.

¹ This is omitted in spoken language when the noun phrase is something that is clearly visible to all interlocutors.

This phrase is ill-formed because *nq̃n* /Nʰeʃ↓Nʰ/ ‘mine’, a noun with work order 6, precedes *rutí* /r̥r̥uʃ↓t̥i↓/ ‘ferrule’, a noun with work order 4. To correct this, we need to move ‘mine’ to the end of the clause, but we can’t simply move the entire enclosing PP as that would change the meaning of the phrase:

ún xúsʷr̥ŋgi tchúʷi ta-rutí tsíʀo nq̃n.

ún xúsʷr̥ŋgi tchúʷi ta-rutí tsíʀo nq̃n
 ũ↓Nʰ ĊXʰũ↓s̥uʷʃ↓r̥r̥kʰʃNʰʃgi↓ ċkċxũʷʃ↓ʔi↓ t̥a↓r̥r̥uʷʃ↓t̥i↓ t̥s̥i↓r̥r̥kʰʃ Nʰeʃ↓Nʰʰ
 for Master Carbonator three POSS-ferrule under mine
 ‘three ferrules under the mine for the Master Carbonators’

While well-formed, this movement has changed what NP the PP qualifies. Instead, the proper solution is to replace the problematic noun in the PP with a **SAP**. The noun is then left stranded as far back in the clause as possible, but of course preceding any nouns with lower work order. If there is no adjective qualifying the noun, the adjective *xún* /ĊXʰũ↓Nʰʰ/ ‘proper’ is used instead. This adjective has no meaning in this context and only serves to provide something the invoice particle can be attached to. Thus, a grammatical rendition of the above might be:

ún xúsʷr̥ŋgi tsíʀo túʀ xún tchúʷi ta-rutí nq̃n.

ún xúsʷr̥ŋgi tsíʀo túʀ xún tchúʷi ta-rutí nq̃n
 ũ↓Nʰ ĊXʰũ↓s̥uʷʃ↓r̥r̥kʰʃNʰʃgi↓ t̥s̥i↓r̥r̥kʰʃ túʀʃ↓r̥r̥ ĊXʰũ↓Nʰʰ ċkċxũʷʃ↓ʔi↓ t̥a↓r̥r̥uʷʃ↓t̥i↓ Nʰeʃ↓Nʰʰ
 for Master Carbonator under INVC.O NULL three POSS-ferrule mine
 ‘three ferrules for the Master Carbonators under the mine’

2.3.2.3 SAP Contraction

Elvish relative clauses (see § 2.10.1) precede the noun they qualify; Elvish NPs are placed after the verb and thus frequently occur at the end of a clause; adjectives precede the noun they qualify and invoice markers in turn precede adjectives. All of these factors combined can lead to a peculiar constellation wherein a SAP directly precedes the NP it refers to, with the same adjective occurring twice in a row. For example, the phrase ‘mortal men who are doomed to retire’ expressed naively in Elvish would end up being:

%dun c̥a s̥án tús̥a úx̥í sh̥anú dun túʀ shardo shardo núg̥í

dun c̥a s̥án tús̥a úx̥í sh̥anú dun túʀ shardo shardo núg̥í
 ɖuʷ↓Nʰ ċkaʃ↓ s̥eʃ↓Nʰʰ t̥úʷ↓s̥aʃ↓ ũʷʃ↓ĊXʰʰʃ↓ s̥haʃ↓Nʰʰũʷʃ↓ ɖuʷ↓Nʰ t̥úʷʃ↓r̥r̥ s̥haʃ↓r̥r̥d̥kʰ s̥haʃ↓r̥r̥d̥kʰ Nʰũʷʃ↓ʃgiʃ↓
 NWK REL VER be.destined MAN retire NWK INV.O mortal mortal human
 ‘mortal men who are doomed to retire’

This is rather awkward, for which reason most Elves instead opt to omit the duplicate adjective:

dun c̥a s̥án tús̥a úx̥í sh̥anú dun túʀ shardo núg̥í

dun c̥a s̥án tús̥a úx̥í sh̥anú dun túʀ shardo núg̥í
 ɖuʷ↓Nʰ ċkaʃ↓ s̥eʃ↓Nʰʰ t̥úʷ↓s̥aʃ↓ ũʷʃ↓ĊXʰʰʃ↓ s̥haʃ↓Nʰʰũʷʃ↓ ɖuʷ↓Nʰ t̥úʷʃ↓r̥r̥ s̥haʃ↓r̥r̥d̥kʰ Nʰũʷʃ↓ʃgiʃ↓
 NWK REL VER be.destined MAN retire NWK INV.O mortal human
 ‘mortal men who are doomed to retire’

In this phrase, *shardo* /s̥haʃ↓r̥r̥d̥kʰ/ ‘mortal’ does double duty and is part both of the SAP *túʀ shardo* /t̥úʷʃ↓r̥r̥ s̥haʃ↓r̥r̥d̥kʰ/ ‘the mortal ones’ as well as the NP *shardo núg̥í* /s̥haʃ↓r̥r̥d̥kʰ Nʰũʷʃ↓ʃgiʃ↓/ ‘mortal men’. A sequence of the form ‘INVOICE.PARTICLE ADJECTIVE NOUN’ is usually SAP-contracted.

2.4 Nouns

Elvish nouns are not marked for number or definiteness. However, besides work order markers (see § 2.4.1), there are a number of miscellaneous noun markers that are used to express concepts such as possession.

The following is a list of Elvish noun markers:

- ◇ *ta-* /tə/ (POSS); this is a possessive marker, e.g. *ta-nánnrú* ‘of the Elves’.

2.4.1 Nouns at Work

Nouns are also declined for whether or not they *perform* work. This is *not* the same as work order! Rather, this marks their position as an agent or patient in any given clause. The verb itself is not declined for voice—this information is contained exclusively in the noun phrase:

- ◇ *tchá* /tʃə/ ‘performs work’ (WRK ‘working’); this is used to mark the agent of a verb that denotes an action that is considered to perform work.
- ◇ *dun* /dʌ/ ‘does not perform work’ (NWK ‘not working’); this is used to mark the agent of a verb that denotes a state or an action that is not considered to perform (worthwhile) work.
- ◇ *úrú* /uː/ ‘has work performed on it’ (WKD ‘worked [on]’); this is used to mark the theme of a verb whose agent is in the WRK form.
- ◇ *úxí* /uː/ ‘is being manipulated in some fashion’ (MAN ‘manipulated’); this is used to mark the theme of a verb whose agent is in the NWK.

This system naturally gives rise to 2 verb classes:

- ◇ ‘working verbs’, whose agent is in the WRK case and whose theme is in the WKD case.
- ◇ ‘lazy verbs’, whose agent is in the NWK case, and whose theme is in the MAN case.

There are also a number of contractions:

- ◇ *tchá* + *úrú* → *tcháúrú* /tʃəuː/ : reflexive form used with working verbs.
- ◇ *dun* + *úxí* → *dunxí* /dʌuː/ : reflexive form used with lazy verbs.

The verb itself is only inflected for tense (see § 2.7.1).

2.4.2 Clause Complements

The noun work markers can also precede the verb, in which case the clause acts as the agent/theme.

2.5 Compounds

Compound nouns can be expressed by juxtaposition; the modifier comes second, just like in Santaa, e.g. *nánnchun* /nəːnʃʌ/ ‘head miner’ (lit. ‘miner head’) from *nánnrú* /nəːnrú/ ‘canary’ and *chunxi* /tʃʌxi/ ‘head’. The compound is written without a space, e.g. *cixítuná* /tʃiːtʌnə/ ‘stone hall’, not **cixí tuná*.

2.6 Pronouns

2.6.1 Demonstrative Pronouns

There are 5 demonstrative pronouns, each corresponding to a syntactic tense (see § 2.7.1); as many other things, deixis in Elvish is relative: unlike other languages which employ spatial metaphors to express time, Elvish employs temporal expressions to express relations in space.

That is, the demonstrative pronouns in Elvish are formed by combining the preposition *chír* /tʃiː/ ‘at, in, on’ with one of the tense morphemes:

1. Awake Tense: *chírsqn* / $\widehat{\zeta}\widehat{x}\widehat{i}\downarrow\widehat{r}\widehat{s}\widehat{q}\widehat{n}^{\uparrow\downarrow}\downarrow$ /
2. REM Sleep Tense: *chírnu* / $\widehat{\zeta}\widehat{x}\widehat{i}\downarrow\widehat{r}\widehat{n}^{\uparrow}\downarrow$ /
3. Non-REM Phase 1 Tense: *chírtxí* / $\widehat{\zeta}\widehat{x}\widehat{i}\downarrow\widehat{r}\widehat{x}\widehat{k}\widehat{x}^{\widehat{h}}\downarrow$ /
4. Non-REM Phase 2 Tense: *chíro* / $\widehat{\zeta}\widehat{x}\widehat{i}\downarrow\widehat{r}\widehat{k}^{\uparrow}\downarrow$ /
5. Non-REM Phase 3 Tense: *chírny* / $\widehat{\zeta}\widehat{x}\widehat{i}\downarrow\widehat{r}\widehat{n}^{\uparrow}\downarrow\widehat{w}^{\uparrow\downarrow}\downarrow$ /

The proximal demonstrative pronoun is expressed relative to the syntactic tense of the utterance: the medial demonstrative pronoun by the tense following the proximal one, and the distal demonstrative pronoun by the tense following the medial one. For example, if the utterance is in the REM Sleep Tense, we have:

- ◇ *chírnu* = ‘this’,
- ◇ *chírtxí* = ‘that (medial)’,
- ◇ *chíro* = ‘that (distal)’.

In the Non-REM Phase 2 Tense, we instead have:

- ◇ *chíro* = ‘this’,
- ◇ *chírny* = ‘that (medial)’,
- ◇ *chírsqn* = ‘that (distal)’.

In reported speech, the direction is reversed, i.e. instead of medial being the tense after proximal and distal being the tense after medial, instead medial is the tense *preceding* proximal, and distal is the tense preceding medial. E.g. the demonstrative pronouns in reported speech that uses the Non-REM Phase 1 Tense would be:

- ◇ *chírnu* = ‘this’,
- ◇ *chírsqn* = ‘that (medial)’,
- ◇ *chírny* = ‘that (distal)’.

Note that it is the only the syntactic tense of the sentence that matters; neither the time of utterance, nor the time at which the utterance is paraphrased, if at all, are relevant here! For example, consider a sentence uttered during the REM Sleep Phase, in which the Non-REM Phase 1 Tense is the syntactic Future Tense. In such a sentence, the medial demonstrative pronoun would be *chíro* / $\widehat{\zeta}\widehat{x}\widehat{i}\downarrow\widehat{r}\widehat{k}^{\uparrow}\downarrow$ /, i.e. the Non-REM Phase 2 form; if this sentence is then paraphrased during the Non-REM Phase 3, the syntactic Future Tense would naturally be the Awake Tense, and the medial pronoun would be the tense *before* that (recall that the direction is reversed in reported speech); thus, the correct form would be *chírny* / $\widehat{\zeta}\widehat{x}\widehat{i}\downarrow\widehat{r}\widehat{n}^{\uparrow}\downarrow\widehat{w}^{\uparrow\downarrow}\downarrow$ /, i.e. the Non-REM Phase 3 form.

2.6.2 Personal Pronouns

There are three sets of constructions in Elvish that are jointly referred to as ‘personal pronouns’. While semantically equivalent, their usage is highly dependent on social status, and they are not interchangeable.

2.6.2.1 Full Personal Pronouns

The so-called *full personal pronouns* of Elvish are formed by combining the demonstrative pronouns with the status-appropriate word for ‘Elf’: The proximal demonstrative is used to express the 1st person, the medial to express the 2nd person, and the distal to express the 3rd person. Naturally, this also means that the exact forms of the personal pronouns depend on the syntactic tense of the containing clause (as well as whether direct or reported speech is used).

For example, in a sentence in Non-REM Phase 2 Tense spoken by a Master Carbonator, the closest Elvish equivalent to a word for ‘I’ would be *chíro xúsyrongi* / $\widehat{\zeta}\widehat{x}\widehat{i}\downarrow\widehat{r}\widehat{k}^{\uparrow}\downarrow\widehat{x}^{\widehat{h}}\widehat{u}\downarrow\widehat{s}\widehat{y}\widehat{r}\widehat{o}\widehat{n}\widehat{g}\widehat{i}\downarrow\widehat{r}\widehat{k}^{\uparrow}\downarrow\widehat{n}^{\uparrow}\downarrow\widehat{g}\widehat{i}\downarrow$ /, lit. ‘this

Master Carbonator’. Similarly, in a sentence paraphrased in Non-REM Phase 3 Tense, the word ‘it’ in reference to a Collier would be *chírtxí isirongi* /ç̣xi↓r̥cḳç̣x̣ḥi↓i↓ṣi↓r̥ḳḥṆʔj̣gi↓/, lit. ‘that Collier’.

2.6.2.2 Abridged Personal Pronouns

There are two forms of ‘abridged’ pronouns: The *high-class* abridged pronouns are formed by combining the demonstratives with the noun *rongi* /r̥ḳḥṆʔj̣gi↓/ ‘cloak’. The *low-class* abridged pronouns are identical to the bare demonstratives. Abridged personal pronouns are only used to refer to an Elf at or below one’s own social status.

2.6.2.3 Usage Notes

Which set of personal pronouns is appropriate in what context is dependent on the social status of the speaker (in the 1st person), as well as that of the referents (in the 2nd and 3rd person). There are strict rules that govern the usage of the pronouns. The rules for the 2nd/3rd person pronouns are:

- ◊ The Chimney Man and The Grand Carbonator are never referred to by a pronoun; instead, the entire phrase ‘The Chimney Man’ or ‘The Grand Carbonator’ is repeated. Similarly, Coal is also never referred to by a pronoun; instead, the noun ‘Coal’ is repeated.
- ◊ The full pronouns are used to refer to an Elf of higher social class than one’s own.
- ◊ The abridged pronouns are used to refer to an Elf at or below one’s own social class. The high-class pronouns are used when the referent is at the class of Collier or above, and the low-class pronouns otherwise.
- ◊ Personal pronouns are only used to refer to Elves. For any other beings, objects, concepts, etc., SAPs (see § 2.3.2) are used instead.
- ◊ Additionally, SAPs may be used whenever an abridged pronoun would be appropriate.

The rules for the 1st person pronoun are simpler: In reference to oneself, the full pronouns are used when speaking to someone of higher social status, and the abridged pronouns otherwise. Naturally, Elves at or above the class of Collier use the high-class pronouns and other Elves the low-class pronouns.

2.6.2.4 Distinguishing Personal and Demonstrative Pronouns

Since personal and demonstrative pronouns can be very similar, as the former simply use the latter, there are rules that can be used to distinguish the two; the most important one of these is that a demonstrative that qualifies the noun always follows the noun. For example, assuming we’re in the REM phase, we have *chírnu rongi* /ç̣xi↓r̥Ṇʔu↓r̥ḳḥṆʔj̣gi↓/ ‘I’ (high-class pronoun) vs *rongi chirnu* /r̥ḳḥṆʔj̣gi↓ç̣xi↓r̥Ṇʔu↓/ ‘this cloak’ (literally).

This is especially important in the context of a zero copula (see § 2.7.3). Consider e.g. *chírtxí tchúrshu* /ç̣xi↓r̥cḳç̣x̣ḥi↓cḳç̣x̣ḥi↓r̥ṣḥu↓/ ‘you are an idiot’ vs *tchúrshu chírtxí* /cḳç̣x̣ḥi↓r̥ṣḥu↓ç̣xi↓r̥cḳç̣x̣ḥi↓/ ‘that idiot’.

2.6.3 Numbers

Elvish numbers use the same system as Santaa numbers, except using Elvish words. Cardinals are expressed using the possessive marker, e.g. *tchúi ta-nánrú* /cḳç̣x̣ḥi↓r̥i↓ta↓Ṇʔv̥ḥṆʔr̥u↓/ ‘three Elves’ (lit. ‘three of Elves’).

2.7 Verbs

Verbs are either classified as ‘working’ or ‘lazy’ (see § 2.4.1). Verbs are not inflected for number, only nouns are. In the absence of work order distinction, the default word order is VOS. Verbs generally do not have an associated work order (unless they are derived from a noun) and are generally placed

first; the main exception to this is that nouns with work order 1 are always placed first and precede even the verb.

2.7.1 Tense, Aspect, Mood

The Elvish tense system is based on the hibernation cycle of The Chimney Man. This cycle consists of 5 phases. These five phases form the five so-called *syntactic tenses* of Elvish, which are each marked by a particle that precedes the verb (see Table 4).

Phase	Gloss	Time of the Year	Particle
Awake	AWK	Christmas Eve	<i>sqn</i> /sɑ ^ḡ ↓N ^ʔ /
REM Sleep	REM	~29 December – 3 May	<i>nun'a</i> /N ^ʔ u↓N ^ʔ a↓/
Non-REM Phase 1	NR1	~4 May – 25 August	<i>txí</i> /ck̥x ^h ↓/
Non-REM Phase 2	NR2	~26 August – 9 November	<i>ronu</i> /r̥ ^k ↓N ^ʔ u↓/
Non-REM Phase 3	NR3	~10 November – 23 December	<i>ronu</i> /r̥ ^k ↓N ^ʔ u ^ḡ ↓/

Table 4: Syntactic Tenses in Elvish

At any point in time, the Present Tense in Elvish is whatever sleep phase The Chimney Man is in when the utterance is spoken. This is referred to as the *semantic tense* of the utterance. For instance, on 2 February, The Chimney Man is in REM sleep, and thus, a sentence whose syntactic tense is the REM Sleep Tense would have the Present Tense as its semantic tense. In terms of terminology, the term ‘syntactic Present Tense’ in any given context refers to whatever syntactic tense happens to be the Present Tense.

The syntactic tense following the Present Tense is the semantic Future Tense, and the syntactic tense after that forms a Future-in-the-Future. Similarly, the syntactic tense preceding the semantic Present Tense forms the Past Tense, and the syntactic tense before that serves as the Pluperfecet.

As nobody truly knows when *exactly* when the Chimney Man falls asleep, the few days following Chrismtas are an enigma to Elvish speakers. They cannot, and out of respect and fear for the Chimney Man, will not express anything related to time. During this time, which often spans from December 25th until December 28th, all tense marking is dropped, and most Elves cease writing entirely, with the upper classes preferring to communicate in Santaa instead. This is known as the ‘Temporal Void’. Reported Speech that paraphrases an utterance that was uttered during the this time likewise uses no tense marking.

The syntactic tense that follows the Non-REM Phase 3 Tense is the Awake Tense; conversely, syntactic tense preceding the Awake tense is the Non-REM Phase 3 Tense. Thus, if the syntactic Present Tense is the Awake Tense, the syntactic Past Tense would be the Non-REM Phase 3 tense.

Tense in reported speech is relative to the time of paraphrase rather than the time of utterance. For example, a sentence spoken *during* the Non-REM Phase 1 but *in* the REM Sleep Tense is in the Past Tense. If reported speech is used to describe or paraphrase that sentence *during* the Non-REM Phase 2, the speaker would use the Non-REM Phase 1 Tense, since that is now the Past Tense.

Thus, one has to be careful not to confuse tense between direct speech and reported speech. For example, given an utterance that was spoken during Non-REM Phase 1 but *in* Non-REM Phase 2 Tense, that utterance refers to the future. But if such an utterance were erroneously reported in that same tense during Non-REM Phase 3, it would incorrectly refer to the past. Instead, the Awake Tense should be used to paraphrase.

Note that the tenses are relative only to the point of utterance, not to the point in time at which the action or state described by the utterance takes place. For example, during Non-REM Phase 1, if one wanted to refer to an event that took place in November of *last year*, one would use the REM Sleep Tense, since that is the syntactic Past Tense. The fact that Non-REM Phase 2 takes place in November does not mean that it is used to describe things that take place in November.

Since a sentence in a vacuum without any information as to when it was uttered is impossible to extract temporal data from, any Elvish prose, etc. is always accompanied by a date, much like a diary entry would be. The exception to this is information uttered during the Temporal Void, during which the date is customarily omitted.

2.7.2 Dependent Clauses

Semantic tense in dependent clauses is relative to the syntactic tense of the matrix clause. For example, during the REM Sleep Phase, the syntactic Future Tense is the Non-REM Phase 1 Tense. Given a matrix clause in this Future Tense, the syntactic Past Tense in one of its dependent clauses would then be the REM Sleep Tense, even though that very same syntactic tense would normally be the syntactic Present Tense during the REM Sleep Phase.

The rules for reported speech for e.g. pronouns also apply to dependent clauses.

2.7.3 Copula

The Elvish copula is $\emptyset$, i.e. the empty root; that is, to express the copula all verb markers are used as they normally would be, except that the verb is ‘missing’. Even the tense and evidentiality marker may be dropped if elision is applied, or if they’re obvious from context, generally if the sentence is in the Present Tense, leading to a zero copula (see § 2.7.7).

If an entire clause is preceded by an agent/theme marker, a zero copula cannot be used, and at least one verb marker (usually the evidentiality marker) is required.

2.7.4 Aspect

Aspect marking differs between working verbs and lazy verbs. Working verbs are marked for telicity, i.e. whether the work is done (TEL ‘telic’) or not (ATEL ‘atelic’). Lazy verbs are marked for whether the laziness is continued (CONT ‘continuous’), or returning (HAB ‘habitual’). For working verbs, telic is the default, for lazy verbs, continuous is the default.

- ◇ *tú* /tú↓/ (ATEL): marks that a working verb is atelic
- ◇ *dor* /dᵒᵏᵗᵗᵗᵗ/ (HAB): marks that a lazy verb is habitual

Aspect markers directly precede the verb.

2.7.5 Moods

[TODO]

2.7.6 Evidentiality

Evidentiality is split five four categories:

- ◇ *sán* /sᵘᵖᵗᵗᵗᵗ/ (VER ‘veridical’): (as though) decreed by The Chimney Man (truth)
- ◇ *gan* /jᵘᵘᵗᵗᵗᵗ/ (OBS ‘observable’): either directly observable or deduced via reasoning
- ◇ *xᵢᵗᵗ* /ᵗᵗᵗᵗᵗᵗᵗᵗᵗ/ (COM ‘communicated’): communicated by someone (hearsay)
- ◇ *txᵗᵗ* /ᵗᵗᵗᵗᵗᵗᵗᵗᵗ/ (NOR ‘North Pole’): purported to exist (in the North Pole)
- ◇ *tsᵗᵗ* /ᵗᵗᵗᵗᵗᵗᵗᵗᵗ/ (DUB ‘dubious’): purported to exist elsewhere

The ‘default’ evidentiality marker is generally *gan* /jᵘᵘᵗᵗᵗᵗ/; it is commonly used for statements which the speaker considers to be true but which are not self-evident or proven facts.

Statements of fact use the Chimney Man evidentiality—for example, $2 + 2 = 4$ —and so do statements that an Elf is absolutely sure about. The meaning of this evidentiality is closer to ‘as true as though The Chimney Man Himself had decreed it’, and a suitable translation may be ‘most surely’. At the same time, it is of course also used to refer to literal statements made by The Chimney Man.

2.7.7 Elision

When multiple verbs in a row have verb markers in common, those markers are often dropped for any verb after the first. In particular, this often applies to evidentiality markers: if the evidentiality marker of several clauses is the same, all but the first are generally dropped.

2.8 Derivation

2.8.1 Vowel Swapping

A common way to turn a noun into a verb in Elvish (or vice versa) that applies solely to disyllabic words is to swap the vowels, e.g. *nánnrú* /Nʰv̥ḡ↓Nʰṛ̥ṽḡ↓/ ‘Coal miner’ becomes *núnrrá* /Nʰṽḡ↓Nʰṛ̥v̥ḡ↓/ ‘to mine Coal’.

2.9 -rú

The suffix *-rú* /ṛ̥ṽḡ↓/ can be attached to a verb or noun to form an agent noun describing an Elf who performs an action associated with that verb or noun. E.g. from *sqtá* /s̥ḡṽḡṽḡṽḡ↓/ ‘to learn’, we get *sqtarrú* /s̥ḡṽḡṽḡṽḡṽḡ↓ṛ̥ṽḡ↓/ ‘teacher’, and from *nánn* /Nʰv̥ḡ↓Nʰv̥ḡ↓/ ‘Coal mine’, we get *nánnrú* /Nʰv̥ḡ↓Nʰṛ̥ṽḡ↓ṛ̥ṽḡ↓/ ‘Coal miner, Elf’.

2.10 Syntax

2.10.1 Relative Clauses

Relative clauses in Elvish are headed by the pronoun *cq* /č̥kaḡ↓/ ‘who, what, which, that’. If the relative pronoun is the agent or theme of the predicate of the relative clause, the appropriate agent or theme marker is placed *before* the relative pronoun. Relative clauses always *precede* the noun they qualify.

There are also two variants of relative clauses that are headed by different pronouns: *locative relative clauses*, which are headed by the pronoun *chírcq* /č̥xi↓ṛ̥č̥kaḡ↓/ ‘where’, and *temporal relative clauses*, which are headed by the pronoun *rícq* /ṛ̥riḡ↓č̥kaḡ↓/ ‘when’.

3 Literary Elvish

There are a few differences between spoken and written Elvish. The most striking difference is a natural consequence of the medium: whereas the time of utterance is obvious in a spoken context (as it is just the present day), the time of utterance of a written text is impossible to know unless expressly conveyed to the reader.

The choice as to what syntactic tense denotes the Present Tense is strictly speaking arbitrary, but by convention, it is generally that of the date on which the author wrote or started writing the text. A natural consequence of this is that many Elves cease all writing during the Temporal Void.

When it comes to stories, poems, etc. only the written form of these texts have a fixed syntactic tense. When a story is told by an Elf, it will naturally—and indeed subconsciously without requiring active consideration or effort—rephrase the text by adjusting the syntactic tense relative to the time at which the story is told while preserving the text’s semantic tense.

Since the time of utterance is an integral part of Elvish grammar, it is custom in Elvish literature to introduce every piece of written text with the phrase ‘This Elf declares that’, with the status-appropriate abridged personal pronoun used as the subject. The syntactic tense of this phrase denotes the Present

Tense for the rest of the text. E.g. if the text is written by a Collier during the REM sleep phase, the phrase would be:

Gan nun'a tú tshú'á tchá chírnú róngi ...

gan nun'a tú tshú'á tchá chírnú róngi
 jga↓N? N'uu↓N?ʔa↓ tũ↓ tšh'ũ↓ʔe↓ ckçxpe↓ çxi↓rñN'ui↓ rñk+ʔN'jgi↓
 OBS REM ATEL declare WRK this cloak
 'I declare that ...'¹

This is effectively prefixed to the first sentence of the text proper, thereby forming a new matrix clause around it. As a result, the rest of the first sentence is rendered in reported speech.

4 Examples

4.1 Simple Glosses

It is assumed that the examples below are spoken on 2 February (i.e. during the REM phase).

Gan nun'a rōsa úxí tá dun txōncu.

gan nun'a rōsa úxí tá dun txōncu
 jga↓N? N'uu↓N?ʔa↓ rñk+ʔsa↓ ũ↓çxh'f↓ tpe↓ dui↓N? ckçxhk+ʔN'ckui↓
 OBS REM slide MAN chimney NWK Txōncu
 'Txōncu slides down the Chimney (and I see it do so).'

Sán sən sōtā dishá dun chírsən róngi úxí chírnú tchúrshu.

sán sən sōtā dishá dun chírsən róngi úxí chírnú tchúrshu
 še↓N? šaʔ↓N? šk+ʔtaʔ↓ di↓šheʔ↓ dui↓N? çxi↓rñsaʔ↓N? rñk+ʔN'jgi↓ ũ↓çxh'f↓ çxi↓rñN'ui↓ ckçxũʔ↓rñšhui↓
 VER AWK know always NWK DEM.AWK cloak MAN DEM.REM idiot
 'I always knew that you were an idiot.'

Lit. 'This cloak most surely always knew [that] that(MEDIAL) [was observably an] idiot.'

Gan nun'a gūshā dun nānrú chir dāchā.

gan nun'a gūshā dun nānrú chir dāchā
 jga↓N? N'uu↓N?ʔa↓ jguʔ↓šhaʔ↓ dui↓N? N'peʔ↓N?rñũʔ↓ çxi↓rñ deʔ↓çxaʔ↓
 OBS REM crouch NWK Elf on table
 'The Elf crouches on the table.'

4.2 Ferrule Verse

An Elvish adaptation of JRR Tolkien's Ring Verse, as translated and adapted by the Elvish poet *Tprxi* /t̥k+ʔrñçxh'f↓/:

4.2.1 Original English Text

*Three Rings for the Elven-kings under the sky,
 Seven for the Dwarf-lords in their halls of stone,
 Nine for Mortal Men doomed to die,
 One for the Dark Lord on his dark throne*

¹ Lit. 'This cloak is observably declaring that ...'

*In the Land of Mordor where the Shadows lie.
 One Ring to rule them all, One Ring to find them,
 One Ring to bring them all and in the darkness bind them
 In the Land of Mordor where the Shadows lie.*

4.2.2 Poetic English Rendition of the Elvish Adaptation

*This Elf declares:
 Three Ferrules for the Master Carbonators under the mine,
 Seven for the Colliers in their halls of stone,
 Nine for Mortal Men doomed to retire,
 One for The Chimney Man on His red throne
 At the North Pole where the Shadows lie.
 One Ferrule to rule them all, One Ferrule to find them,
 One Ferrule to bring them all and in the Arctic bind them
 At the North Pole where the Shadows lie.*

4.2.3 Elvish Adaptation

*Gan nun'a tú tshú'á tchá chírnú róngi.
 Úrú gan ún xúsúrongi tsíro túr xún tchú'i ta-rutí nán.
 Úrú gan ún isirongi chír cúr xún txadq irtototon cixítunq.
 Úrú gan txadq cuncuton ún dun cq sán túsq úxí shanú dun túr shardo núgí.
 Ún Sántq chír túr isi ta-Sántq úrú gan txadq nangí shindí nurchq
 Chír chírcq chonsq dun árxí xún txácq ánrú.
 Ún ta-dorq nangí ta-rutí. Ún ta-shunsí úrú txadq shú.
 Ún ta-xítí nangí ta-rutí. Ún ta-tsantú chír xurgí
 Chír chírcq chonsq dun árxí xún txácq ánrú.*

4.2.4 Gloss of the Elvish Adaptation

Gan nun'a tú tshú'á tchá chírnú róngi.

gan nun'a tú tshú'á tchá chírnú róngi
 jga↓N? N'uu↓N?Ta↓ tũ↓ tsh'ũ↓f̃g↓ṽe↓ ck̃x̃e↓f̃g↓ ̃xi↓r̃N'ũ↓ r̃k̃f̃g↓N'jgi↓
 OBS REM ATEL declare WRK this cloak
 'This Elf declares:'

Úrú gan ún xúsúrongi tsíro túr xún tchú'i ta-rutí nán.

úrú gan ún xúsúrongi tsíro túr xún tchú'i ta-rutí
 ũ↓f̃g↓r̃ũ↓f̃g↓ jga↓N? ũ↓N? ̃x̃h̃ũ↓s̃ũ↓f̃g↓r̃k̃f̃g↓N'jgi↓ t̃si↓r̃k̃f̃g↓ tũ↓f̃g↓r̃k̃ ̃x̃h̃ũ↓N? ck̃x̃ũ↓f̃g↓i↓ ta↓r̃ũ↓f̃g↓t̃i↓
 WKD OBS for Master Carbonator under INV.O NULL three POSS-ferrule
 nán
 N'ṽe↓N?
 mine
 '[That there are] three Ferrules for the Master Carbonators under the mine'

Úrú gan ún isirongi chír cúr xún txadá irtòtòtòn cìxítún'á.

úrú gan ún isirongi chír cúr xún txadá irtòtòtòn
 ǔǔ↓ǔǔ↓ǔǔ↓ jǔga↓N? ǔǔ↓N? i↓sǔi↓ǔǔ↓ǔǔ↓N? jǔgi↓ ǔǔ↓ǔǔ↓ ǔǔ↓ǔǔ↓ǔǔ↓ ǔǔ↓ǔǔ↓N? ǔǔ↓ǔǔ↓ǔǔ↓ǔǔ↓ǔǔ↓ i↓ǔǔ↓ǔǔ↓ǔǔ↓ǔǔ↓ǔǔ↓N?
 WKD OBS for Collier in INV.-1 NULL WO+7 seven
 cìxí tǔn'á
 ǔǔ↓ǔǔ↓ǔǔ↓ǔǔ↓ ǔǔ↓ǔǔ↓N? ǔǔ↓ǔǔ↓
 hall stone

'[That there are] seven for the Colliers in their halls of stone'

Úrú gan txadá cuncutòn ún dun cǎ sǎn túsǎ úxí shǎnú dun túr shardo núgí.

úrú gan txadá cuncutòn ún dun cǎ sǎn túsǎ úxí
 ǔǔ↓ǔǔ↓ǔǔ↓ jǔga↓N? ǔǔ↓ǔǔ↓ǔǔ↓ǔǔ↓ǔǔ↓ ǔǔ↓ǔǔ↓ǔǔ↓ǔǔ↓ǔǔ↓N? ǔǔ↓N? ǔǔ↓N? ǔǔ↓ǔǔ↓ ǔǔ↓N? ǔǔ↓ǔǔ↓ǔǔ↓ǔǔ↓ ǔǔ↓ǔǔ↓ǔǔ↓ǔǔ↓
 WKD OBS WO+7 nine for NWK REL VER be.destined MAN
 shǎnú dun túr shardo núgí
 ǔǔ↓ǔǔ↓ǔǔ↓ǔǔ↓ ǔǔ↓N? ǔǔ↓ǔǔ↓ǔǔ↓ ǔǔ↓ǔǔ↓ǔǔ↓ǔǔ↓ N? ǔǔ↓ǔǔ↓ǔǔ↓
 retire NWK INV.0 mortal human

'[That there are] nine for Mortal Men [who are] doomed to retire'

Ún Sǎntǎ chír túr isi ta-Sǎntǎ úrú gan txadá nangí shindí nurchò.

ún Sǎntǎ chír túr isi ta-Sǎntǎ úrú gan
 ǔǔ↓N? ǔǔ↓ǔǔ↓ǔǔ↓ǔǔ↓ ǔǔ↓ǔǔ↓ǔǔ↓ǔǔ↓ i↓sǔi↓ ǔǔ↓ǔǔ↓ǔǔ↓ǔǔ↓ǔǔ↓ ǔǔ↓ǔǔ↓ǔǔ↓ǔǔ↓ǔǔ↓ jǔga↓N?
 for The Chimney Man on INV.0 red POSS-The Chimney Man WKD OBS
 txadá nangí shindí nurchò
 ǔǔ↓ǔǔ↓ǔǔ↓ǔǔ↓ǔǔ↓ N? ǔǔ↓N? ǔǔ↓ǔǔ↓ǔǔ↓ ǔǔ↓ǔǔ↓ǔǔ↓ N? ǔǔ↓ǔǔ↓ǔǔ↓ǔǔ↓
 WO+7 one WO+10 throne

'[That there is] one for The Chimney Man on His red throne'

Chír chírcǎ chònsò dun árxí xún txáccǎ ánrú.

chír chírcǎ chònsò dun árxí xún txáccǎ ánrú
 ǔǔ↓ǔǔ↓ǔǔ↓ ǔǔ↓ǔǔ↓ǔǔ↓ǔǔ↓ǔǔ↓ ǔǔ↓ǔǔ↓ǔǔ↓ǔǔ↓ǔǔ↓ ǔǔ↓ǔǔ↓ǔǔ↓ǔǔ↓ǔǔ↓ ǔǔ↓ǔǔ↓ǔǔ↓ǔǔ↓ǔǔ↓ ǔǔ↓ǔǔ↓ǔǔ↓ǔǔ↓ǔǔ↓
 at where reside NWK INV.+2 NULL the North Pole shadow
 'At the North Pole where the Shadows lie.'

Ún ta-dorǎ nangí ta-rutí

ún ta-dorǎ nangí ta-rutí
 ǔǔ↓N? ǔǔ↓ǔǔ↓ǔǔ↓ǔǔ↓ǔǔ↓ N? ǔǔ↓N? ǔǔ↓ǔǔ↓ǔǔ↓ǔǔ↓
 for POSS-rule one POSS-ferrule
 'One Ferrule to rule,'

Ún ta-shǔnsí úrú txadá shú.

ún ta-shǔnsí úrú txadá shú.
 ǔǔ↓N? ǔǔ↓ǔǔ↓ǔǔ↓ǔǔ↓ǔǔ↓ ǔǔ↓ǔǔ↓ǔǔ↓ǔǔ↓ǔǔ↓ ǔǔ↓ǔǔ↓ǔǔ↓ǔǔ↓ǔǔ↓ ǔǔ↓ǔǔ↓ǔǔ↓
 for POSS-find WKD WO+7 all
 'To find them all'

Ún ta-xítí nangí ta-rutí

ún ta-xítí nangí ta-rutí
 ǔǔ↓N? ǔǔ↓ǔǔ↓ǔǔ↓ǔǔ↓ǔǔ↓ N? ǔǔ↓N? ǔǔ↓ǔǔ↓ǔǔ↓ǔǔ↓
 for POSS-bring one POSS-ferrule
 'One Ferrule to bring,'

Ún ta-tsantú chíx xurgi·

ún ta-tsantú chíx xurgi

ũ↓N? ta↓t̥sa↓N?tũ↓ ĊXI↓R̥ ĊX^hu↓R̥gi^ŋ↓

for POSS-bind in arctic

‘To bind [them] in the Arctic.’

4.2.5 Notes

The sentence *Úrú gan txadq cuncutqon ún dun cq sán túsq úxí shqnú dun túr shardo núgí* is very complex and serves as a good illustration of some of the quirks of Elvish grammar:

- ◇ *úrú* /ũ^ŋ↓R̥ũ^ŋ↓/ marks that the entire clause is an object of the verb *tshúá* /t̥sh^hũ^ŋ↓ʔe↓/ ‘declare’ in the first clause. It can be translated as the English subordinator ‘that’ in this context.
- ◇ The evidentiality marker *gan* /jga↓N?/ qualifies the copula, which has no root. It is required here to prevent *úrú* from affecting only the following noun phrase, as it must precede a verb (marker) to affect the entire clause.
- ◇ *txadq cuncutqon* /ċkċx^ha↓d̥p̥^ŋ↓ ċkuu↓N?ċkuu↓t̥k^ŋ↓N?/ is simply the word for the number 9 (whose default work order is w11) raised by 7 work orders to give it work order w4 to match *rutí* /r̥u^ŋ↓t̥i↓/ ‘ferrule’ in the second clause, which is elided here. Thus, this phrase literally means ‘nine of the thing with work order w4’.
- ◇ The complement of the PP headed by *ún* /ũ↓N?/ ‘for’ is the rest of the clause.

In particular, the relative clause *dun cq sán túsq úxí shqnú dun túr shardo* ‘which are destined to retire’ is fairly complicated on its own:

- ◇ The NP it modifies, *shardo núgí* /š^ha↓R̥d̥k̥t̥ N?ũ↓jgr̥^ŋ↓/ ‘mortal humans’, follows the clause rather than preceding it.
- ◇ Notably, the relative pronoun *cq* /ċka^ŋ↓/ is not the first word in the clause. Rather, because it is the subject of a clause with a lazy verb, it is preceded by the lazy agent marker *dun* /d̥u↓N?/.
- ◇ The complement of *túsq* /t̥ũ↓sa^ŋ↓/ ‘to be destined’ is yet another clause, viz. *shqnú dun túr shardo* ‘the mortal ones retire’.
- ◇ This inner clause is preceded by the lazy theme marker *úxí* /ũ^ŋ↓ċx^hr̥^ŋ↓/, which marks that the clause is the theme of *túsq* /t̥ũ↓sa^ŋ↓/.
- ◇ The sequence *túr shardo núgí* /t̥ũ^ŋ↓R̥ š^ha↓R̥d̥k̥t̥ N?ũ↓jgr̥↓/ is SAP-contracted (see § 2.3.2.3) and is short for *túr shardo shardo núgí* /t̥ũ^ŋ↓R̥ š^ha↓R̥d̥k̥t̥ š^ha↓R̥d̥k̥t̥ N?ũ↓jgr̥↓/. That is, we have a SAP *túr shardo* /t̥ũ^ŋ↓R̥ š^ha↓R̥d̥k̥t̥/ ‘the mortal ones’, which agrees with *núgí* /N?ũ↓jgr̥^ŋ↓/ ‘human’ and its referent is the NP *shardo núgí* /š^ha↓R̥d̥k̥t̥ N?ũ↓jgr̥^ŋ↓/ ‘mortal humans’.

In sum, this sentence is a dependent clause that contains a relative clause whose theme is another clause, and both inner clauses either modify or reference an NP that occurs later on in the sentence.

4.2.6 Notes to add to the grammar.

- ◇ The interpunct is the only punctuation mark and functions as a full stop, semicolon, colon, and comma.
- ◇ The particle ‘that’ as in ‘I declare that’ is expressed by placing the theme marker before the verb of the ‘that’-clause, or before the entire clause if there is no verb (zero copula).
- ◇ In poetry, movement of nouns due to work order is restricted to within a line rather than within a clause.

4.2.7 Literal Translation of the Elvish Adaptation

This Elf declares:

That there are three Ferrules for the Master Carbonators under the mine

That there are seven for the Colliers in their stone-halls

That there are nine for Mortal Men [who are] destined to retire

That there is one for The Chimney Man on The Chimney Man's red throne

At the North Pole where the Shadows reside

One Ferrule to rule, to find them all

One Ferrule to bring, to bind [them] in the Arctic.

At the North Pole where the Shadows reside

5 Appearance and Culture

5.1 Gender

Elves have no concept of gender and are each referred to as 'it'. They also do not reproduce naturally and are instead all created by The Chimney Man.

5.2 The Carbonators

At the very top of Elvish society stands the council of Master Carbonators. This council consists of a dozen or so Elves who are assigned a work order of 3.

The council is ruled over by the Grand Carbonator. It is the sole Elf that is assigned a work order of 2, and who is thus considered equally important to the Elves as Coal itself. The Grand Carbonator is effectively the right-hand Elf of The Chimney Man and reports to Him in person every Christmas Eve.

5.3 Elvish Upper Class

The social classes of Collier and Master Carbonator comprise the upper classes of Elvish society; these Elves are easily identified as only they are entitled to wear *rŋngi* /r̥ŋ^{k+ŋ}N[?]ŋgi↓/ 'cloaks'. These cloaks come in three forms:

- ◇ Colliers wear crimson cloaks and are thus commonly referred to as *isirŋngi* /i↓s̥i↓r̥ŋ^{k+ŋ}N[?]ŋgi↓/ 'redcloaks'.
- ◇ Master Carbonators wear crimson cloaks embroidered with black patterns of Coal and are thus commonly referred to as *xúsyrŋngi* /ç̥x̥^hũ↓s̥u^ŋ↓r̥ŋ^{k+ŋ}N[?]ŋgi↓/ 'blackcloaks'.
- ◇ Finally, the Grand Carbonator's cloak is entirely black and coated with Coal; for this reason, the Grand Carbonator is commonly referred to as *Shŋnxarŋngi* /š̥^{hk+ŋ}N[?]ç̥x̥^ha^ŋ↓r̥ŋ^{k+ŋ}N[?]ŋgi↓/ 'Coal cloak'.

Lower-class Elves who pretend to have a higher social class than they actually do are referred to as *ishúrŋngi* /i↓s̥^hũ↓r̥ŋ^{k+ŋ}N[?]ŋgi↓/ 'fake cloaks'; wearing a cloak that corresponds to a higher class than one's own is generally punished by decommissioning (see § 5.4).

Other Elves do not wear any clothes at all. The common Elf instead keeps itself warm in the freezing temperatures of the Arctic by burning the Coal it consumes inside its ventral furnace.

5.4 ‘Retirement’

A central concept in Elvish society is *shúnq* /ʃʰũŋʳNʳaʳq↓/ ‘retirement’. Elves never stop working; that is, an Elf only ‘retires’ at the moment of its death. In some cases, Elves who have acted out of line or otherwise disrupted the Coal mining process—or worse, slighted The Chimney Man—can be ‘decommissioned’, which entails *actively* ‘retiring’ an Elf. This is also known as ‘dishonourable retirement’.

Elves that retire honourably are given a *Shonxqshúnq* /ʃʰkʰʳNʳʧʰaʳq↓ʃʰũŋʳNʳaʳq↓/ ‘Coal burial’, i.e. they are cremated in such a way as to turn them into Coal, thus contributing to Elvish society even after their demise.

5.5 Refurbishment

Refurbishment is the act of promoting an Elf from a lower social class into a higher social class; this is a rare occurrence and only awarded to Elves for distinguished acts of service in the mines. For instance, a canary that consistently delivers twice the amount of Coal compared to its co-workers may be promoted to head miner after some time once new tunnels are constructed.

Similarly, a Head Miner that oversees a particularly large Coal mine or even several coal mines may eventually be promoted to a Collier if their area of management grows too large for an Elf of its status.

Upon becoming a Collier or Master Carbonator, an Elf is rewarded with a *rongi* /ŋʳkʰʳNʳŋi↓/ ‘cloak’, which is subsequently sewn onto it, thus completing the refurbishment process and clearly demarcating them as now part of a higher social class than its former peers.

Below the class of Collier, candidates for refurbishment are selected by Colliers. Candidates for the class of Collier are selected by the Master Carbonators, and candidates for the latter class directly by The Grand Carbonator. An Elf cannot become The Grand Carbonator. If The Grand Carbonator retires, a new one is constructed by The Chimney Man.

Refurbishment has no corresponding opposite process: if an Elf does something that causes it to fall below its social class, only decommissioning awaits it.

5.6 Sleep

Elves never sleep prior to their retirement. In Elvish, there are indeed two different words for ‘sleeping’; one that refers to the most sacred and noble hibernation of The Chimney Man, and which therefore naturally assigned a work order of 1 and which can indeed refer only to the sleep of The Chimney Man.

The other word, conversely, has word order 11 and is associated primarily with the sleep of humans and other lesser beings. Elves consider this form of sleep nothing but a waste of time.

Thus, it should also come as no surprise that The Chimney Man’s hibernating is considered a working verb, as The Chimney Man always works the Hardest and therefore His hibernation must obviously be some to the Elves unfathomable form of work. Normal sleeping, by contrast, is a lazy verb.

5.7 Physical Description

- ◇ Elves have no lips, making their sharp and pointy teeth, which are designed for the chewing and consumption of Coal, by which they are perpetually stained a dark and dusty black, clearly visible.
- ◇ Elvish tongues are extremely stiff and don’t bend.
- ◇ Elvish eyes are covered in multiple levels of eye lashes to keep the Coal out of their vision. Since the Elvish eye has evolved to thrive in an exceedingly dry and dusty environment, Elves naturally never need to close their eyes and thus lack eyelids.

- ◇ Elves have pointy ears, but they point downwards, so as to not collide with the low ceiling of their mines.
- ◇ Lower-class Elves (below the class of Collier) are typically always hunched down so as to fit in lower tunnels.
- ◇ Elves have inverted knees, so as to improve crawling in tunnel conditions.
- ◇ Elves are closer to Coal golems than biological creatures.
- ◇ The throat and mouth of an Elf is constantly extremely dry due to being coated in Coal dust, which renders their articulation extremely hoarse, strained, and outright grating.
- ◇ The complexion of an Elf is a dark grey, simply because they are always covered in layers upon layers of coal; no-one actually knows what the natural skin colour of an Elf is.
- ◇ Elves are mostly bald; the most hair they have on their bodies is their eye lashes.

5.8 Idioms

Since Coal is the most important aspect of Elvish society, many idioms and phrases in Elvish revolve around Coal and anything involved in the Coal mining process. For example, whereas in English a seam of Coal may be referred to as a ‘coal vein’ in analogy with the veins of the human body, Elvish does the opposite: the term *shú’i ta-xqro* /ʃʰuːiː taːxˈqro/ ‘blood vessel’ literally means ‘tunnel of blood’, where *shú’i* is the term for a tunnel in a Coal mine.

6 April Fool’s notes for the server

- ◇ Make some images and emojis etc. for the Discord server. Make it coal-themed.
- ◇ Rename ‘general’ and ‘general-2’ to ‘mining’ and ‘mining-2’.
- ◇ Change the server icon to a picture of Coal.
- ◇ Rename the server to ‘Agma’s Colliery’.
- ◇ Rename Agma to ‘The Chimney Man’.
- ◇ Rename Ætérnal to ‘The Grand Carbonator’
- ◇ Some of the mods can rename themselves to ‘Master Carbonator’.
- ◇ Change all role colours to shades of grey/black (save the previous colours so they can be restored); only Agma’s role as the Chimney Man should remain red.
- ◇ Don’t rename the roles to people can still ping them for moderation purposes.
- ◇ Rename the MC channel to ‘coal-mining’
- ◇ Give everyone on the server free Coal.
- ◇ Leave everything that way for a week.
- ◇ Note to Ætérnal: start preparing assets for that; apply all of this when I wake up the day the video comes out. Change my profile picture to Coal. Prepare all of this on my test server ahead of time so I can simply copy the settings.

7 Dictionary

Lazy verbs are marked with *lz*, working verbs with *wk*.

ánrú /v↓N²rúw↓/ *n. w11* Shadow.

ca /cka↓/ *pron.* Which, who, what,. *Introduces a relative clause* (see § 2.10.1).

cáru /ckv↓rúw↓/ *Work order lowering marker*; see § 2.2.

chír /çxi↓r/ *prep.* At, on, in, near.

chírca /çxi↓rcka↓/ *pron.* [contraction of **chír** and **ca**, lit. ‘in which’] Where. *Introduces a locative relative clause* (see § 2.10.1).

chonsq /çxk↓N²sḡk↓/ *v. lz* Reside, live.

chunxi /çxu↓N²çxh↓/ *n. w11* Head.

cícha /ckr↓çxa↓/ *Work Order raising marker*; see § 2.2.

cixí /cki↓çxh↓/ *n. w11* Hall.

cuncu /ckw↓N²ckw↓/ *n. w11* [sense 2 is a calque of Santaa **õh**]

1. Logistics.

2. The number 8.

cuncuton /ckw↓N²ckw↓tḡk↓N²/ *n. w11* [from **cuncu** and **ton**; literally ‘logistics more’, a calque of Santaa **õh hõ**] The number 9.

dácha /dɛ↓çxa↓/ *n. w11* Table.

dígá /dɪ↓jge↓/ *n. w11* Cane.

dishá /di↓sḡv↓/ *adv.*

1. Always. *In a sentence with positive polarity.*

2. Never. *In a sentence with negative polarity.*

dora /dḡk↓ra↓/ *v.*

1. *wk* To rule, reign (+WKD over sbd./sth.).

gan /jga↓N²/ *particle* [from **gantú**] Evidentiality marker; see § 2.7.6.

gantú /jga↓N²túw↓/ *v.* To see.

gincú /jgi↓N²ckw↓/ *Work order lowering marker*; see § 2.2.

gusha /jgu↓sḡha↓/ *v. lz* To crouch, be crouched.

igá /i↓jge↓/ *n. w11* Poem.

ínú /i↓N²úw↓/ *n. w6* Minecart.

irgu /i↓rḡgu↓/ *v.* [sense 2 is a calque of Santaa **hõ**]

1. To build.

2. The number 4.

irtõn /i↓rḡtḡk↓N²/ *n. w11* [from **irgu** and **ton**; literally ‘build more more’, a calque of Santaa **hõ hõ**] The number 5.

irtõtõn /i↓rḡtḡk↓tḡk↓N²/ *n. w11* [from **irgu** and **ton**; literally ‘build more more’, a calque of Santaa **hõ hõ hõ**] The number 6.

irtõtõtõn /i↓rḡtḡk↓tḡk↓tḡk↓N²/ *n. w11* [from **irgu** and **ton**; literally ‘build more more more’, a calque of Santaa **hõ hõ hõ hõ**] The number 7.

ishú /i↓sḡúw↓/ *n. w11*

1. Charcoal.

2. *fig.* Something that is fake or wrong; fraud; impostor.

ishúrõngi /i↓sḡúw↓rḡk↓N²jgi↓/ *n. w11* [from **ishú** and **rõngi**] Someone who pretends to have a higher social class than they actually do. *Lit.* ‘false cloak’; see § 5.3.

isi /i↓si↓/ *adj. w11* Red.

isirõngi /i↓si↓rḡk↓N²jgi↓/ *n. w4* [from **isi** and **rõngi**] Collier. *Lit.* ‘redcloak’; see § 5.3.

nân /N²vḡ↓N²/ *n. w6* Coal mine.

nânchun /N²vḡ↓N²çxu↓N²/ *n. w5* [from **nân** and **chunxi** ‘head’] Head Miner.

nângá /N²vḡ↓N²jge↓/ *n. w11* Communication.

nângásánsḡ /N²vḡ↓N²jge↓sḡvḡN²sḡúw↓/ *n. w6* [from **nângá** and **sánsḡ**, lit. ‘workplace communication’] The Elvish language.

nangí /N²a↓N²jgr↓/ *n. w11* [sense 2 is a calque of Santaa **hõ**]

1. December.

2. The number 1.

nân /N²vḡ↓N²rḡúw↓/ *n.* [from **nân**]

1. *w7* Coal miner.

2. *w6* Elf, canary. *All Elves are coal miners, whence this sense follows naturally. This is the Generic term for an Elf whose social status is unknown, as well as the term for Canaries.*

natá /N²a↓tḡv↓/ *Work Order raising marker*; see § 2.2.

núgí /N²úw↓jgr↓/ *n. w11* Human, man, woman. *Elves do not distinguish between gender in other species as they have no gender themselves.*

nún /N²úw↓N²rḡv↓/ *v. w6* [from **nân**]

1. To mine Coal.

2. To be alive.

nurchq /N²úw↓rḡçxk↓/ *n. w11* Throne.

oxa /kḡçxha↓/ *Work order lowering marker*; see § 2.2.

ríca /rḡi↓cka↓/ *pron.* [contraction of **rídu** and **ca**] When. *Introduces a temporal relative clause* (see § 2.10.1).

rídu /rḡi↓duw↓/ *adv.* Then, afterwards.

ringú /rḡi↓N²gúw↓/ *n. w11* Handle.

rõngi /rḡk↓N²jgi↓/ *n. w4*

1. Cloak. *This specifically refers to a type of cloak worn only by Colliers and Master Carbonators.*
2. Elf (upper class). *This term refers to Elves at the class of Collier and above. Formally, only Elves who are themselves Colliers or higher are allowed to use **rɔŋgi** on its own to refer to a high-class Elf. Lower-class Elves sometimes do so too, but only amongst themselves.*
- rɔsa** /rɔ˥kɔ˥sa˥/ v. lz. To slide.
- rutí** /rɔ˥wɔ˥tɪ˥/ n. w4 Ferrule.
- sán** /sɛ˥n˥/ particle [reduced form of **sán**] Evidentiality marker; see § 2.7.6.
- sán** /sɛ˥n˥/ n. w11 Being.
- sánshú** /sɛ˥n˥sɰ˥hɰ˥/ n. w11 Workplace.
- Sántá** /sɛ˥n˥tɛ˥/ n. w1 [from **sán** and **tá**; direct borrowing from Santaa *hǎ òh ǎh hǎ òh ǎh hq̣*] The Chimney Man. Always capitalised, unless derogatory lowering is applied. This noun is never declined for number as there is, has been, and will only ever be one Chimney Man.
- sántɔ** /sɛ˥n˥tɔ˥kɔ˥/ n. w11 Place.
- shánú** /ʂhɰ˥a˥n˥wɰ˥/ v. lz [see also **shúná**] To retire.
- shardo** /ʂhɰ˥a˥rɔ˥dɔ˥kɔ˥/ adj. Mortal.
- shatú** /ʂhɰ˥a˥tɔ˥wɰ˥/ Work order lowering marker; see § 2.2.
- shindí** /ʂhɰ˥i˥n˥dɪ˥/ Work Order raising marker; see § 2.2.
- shɪndɪ** /ʂhɰ˥i˥n˥dɪ˥wɰ˥/ Work order lowering marker; see § 2.2.
- shító** /ʂhɰ˥i˥tɔ˥kɔ˥/ Work Order raising marker; see § 2.2.
- Shɔnxá** /ʂhɰ˥kɔ˥n˥ʂhɰ˥a˥/ n. w2 Coal. The most important noun in Elvish, second only to The Chimney Man. This word and all words derived from it are always capitalised.
- Shɔnxarɔŋgi** /ʂhɰ˥kɔ˥n˥ʂhɰ˥a˥rɔ˥ŋgi˥/ n. w2 [from **Shɔnxá** and **rɔŋgi**] Grand Carbonator. Lit. ‘coal cloak’; see § 5.3.
- Shɔnxáshúná** /ʂhɰ˥kɔ˥n˥ʂhɰ˥a˥ʂhɰ˥wɰ˥a˥/ n. w2 [from **Shɔnxá** and **shúná**] Coal burial. See § 5.4.
- shú** /ʂhɰ˥wɰ˥/ n. w11
1. Whole, entirety, everything.
2. All, every. Used like a number.
- shú’i** /ʂhɰ˥wɰ˥i˥/ n. w11
1. A tunnel in a Coal mine.
2. **shú’i ta-xaro** Blood vessel. Lit. ‘blood tunnel’.
- shúná** /ʂhɰ˥wɰ˥a˥n˥/ n. w4 [see also **shúná**] Retirement. See § 5.4.
- shunsí** /ʂhɰ˥wɰ˥sɪ˥/ v.
1. lz To encounter, meet.
2. wk To find, discover.
- sɔtá** /sɔ˥kɔ˥tɔ˥/ v.
1. lz To know.
2. wk To learn.
- sɔtarú** /sɔ˥kɔ˥tɔ˥rɔ˥wɰ˥/ n. w6 [from **sɔtá**] Teacher.
- tá-** /tɛ˥/ particle Possessive marker; this is placed directly before a noun (even in a noun phrase) and is always unstressed.
- ◊ **tá-Sántá** ‘of The Chimney Man’.
- ◊ **ríngú isi tá-dígá** ‘handles of red canes’.
- tá** /tɛ˥/ n. w4 Chimney.
- tchan’ú** /tɕkɕɰ˥a˥n˥wɰ˥/ Work order lowering marker; see § 2.2.
- tchatu** /tɕkɕɰ˥a˥tɔ˥wɰ˥/ n. w11 Work.
- tchichá** /tɕkɕɰ˥i˥tɕɰ˥/ Work order lowering marker; see § 2.2.
- tchixi** /tɕkɕɰ˥i˥tɕɰ˥i˥/ Work Order raising marker; see § 2.2.
- tchú’i** /tɕkɕɰ˥wɰ˥i˥/ n. w11 [sense 2 is a calque of Santaa *òh*]
1. Plan.
2. The number 3.
- tchúrshu** /tɕkɕɰ˥wɰ˥rɔ˥shɰ˥/ n. w11 Idiot, moron. This is derogatory and thus always has word order 11.
- tɔn** /tɔ˥kɔ˥n˥/ adj. More.
- tɔrxí** /tɔ˥kɔ˥rɔ˥xɰ˥i˥/ n. Elvish given name.
- tsan’o** /tsɰ˥a˥n˥wɰ˥/ Work order lowering marker; see § 2.2.
- tsantú** /tsɰ˥a˥n˥tɔ˥wɰ˥/ v. wk To bind.
- tshó’o** /tɕhɰ˥kɔ˥tɔ˥kɔ˥/ n. w11 Ribbon.
- tshú’á** /tɕhɰ˥wɰ˥i˥tɛ˥/ v. wk. To declare, make known.
- tsíro** /tsɪ˥rɔ˥kɔ˥/ prep. Under, beneath, below.
- tsún** /tsɰ˥wɰ˥a˥n˥/ particle Evidentiality marker; see § 2.7.6.
- tun’á** /tɔ˥wɰ˥i˥tɛ˥/ n. w11 Stone.
- túsá** /tɔ˥wɰ˥sɰ˥a˥/ v. lz To be destined to ... The object of this verb is a clause; the nested clause has no evidentiality marker.
- txá** /tɕkɕɰ˥hɛ˥/ particle [from **txáca**] Evidentiality marker; see § 2.7.6.
- txáca** /tɕkɕɰ˥hɛ˥tɕkɔ˥/ n. w3 The North Pole.

txadá /ck̥çʰa↓d̥p̥ʰ/ *Work Order raising marker*;
see § 2.2.

txoŋcu /ck̥çʰk̥t̥ʰNʰck̥wʰ/ *n. Elvish given name.*

txúdí /ck̥çʰúʰt̥ʰd̥/ *adj. Fat, big.*

txúnsha /ck̥çʰúʰt̥ʰNʰʂʰa↓/ *Work Order raising marker*; see § 2.2.

ún /úʰt̥ʰNʰ/ *prep.*

1. For.

2. To, towards.

3. In order to, so as to. *Always followed by a verb prefixed with ta-*.

◊ **ún ta-shúnsí** ‘in order to find’. *Lit. ‘for of [to] find’.*

úncho /úʰt̥ʰNʰçʰk̥t̥ʰ/ *Work Order raising marker*;
see § 2.2.

xáŋgá /çʰh̥p̥ʰt̥ʰNʰʂ̥p̥/ *n. w11 Thing.*

xaro /çʰh̥aʰt̥ʰr̥k̥t̥ʰ/ *n. w11 Blood.*

xíntí /çʰh̥t̥ʰt̥ʰNʰt̥ʰ/ *Work Order raising marker*; see § 2.2.

xítí /çʰh̥t̥ʰt̥ʰt̥ʰ/ *v. wk To bring, carry.*

xonchu /çʰh̥k̥t̥ʰNʰçʰwʰ/ *Work order lowering marker*; see § 2.2.

xún /çʰh̥úʰt̥ʰNʰ/ *adj.*

1. Proper, good.

2. Null adjective used in extraposition. See § 2.3.2.2.

xúnna /çʰh̥úʰt̥ʰNʰaʰt̥ʰ/ *Work Order raising marker*; see § 2.2.

xúnrá /çʰh̥úʰt̥ʰNʰr̥p̥/ *Work order lowering marker*; see § 2.2.

xurgi /çʰh̥u↓r̥ʂ̥giʰ/ *n. w3 The Arctic.*

xúsú /çʰh̥úʰs̥wʰ/ *adj. w11 Black.*

xúsurongi /çʰh̥úʰs̥wʰt̥ʰr̥k̥t̥ʰNʰʂ̥giʰ/ *n. w3 [from xúsú and rongi] Master Carbonator. Lit. ‘black-cloak’; see § 5.3 which are embroidered with black Coal-like patterns.*